Make the dungeon the hero

A restrained, tactile fantasy HUD. Preserve the strong portraits and torchlit atmosphere; fix hierarchy before adding decoration.

1 **Close debug by default** Recover the full-width desktop composition. Keep a dedicated developer drawer.

2 **Rebuild the party hierarchy** Portrait, HP, resource, active weapon. Show selection, hurt, downed and cooldown states.

3 **Give phones explicit controls** Two thumb zones for movement and aim; four compact party selectors above them.

4 **Replace repeated gold rectangles** One dark iron frame, warm brass corner caps and a clear selected-state accent.

5 **Shrink the persistent log** One or two messages during play; expandable history. Merge repeated failure messages.

6 **Make actions discoverable** Attack / Aim, Spell, Use and Wait share a stable position and input hints.

7 **Separate scenery and HUD values** Stable opaque text beds; restrained orange fire, cool slate shadows and readable silhouettes.

8 **Make the map navigational** Distinct door, player, objective and explored symbols; stable north-up orientation.

9 **Ship a complete state vocabulary** Aim, hit, cooldown, disabled, downed, tooltip, dialogue and inventory use the same components.

10 **Add short, functional motion** Fast press, damage catch-up and drawer transitions; reduced-motion alternative.

Budget rule: spend on reusable 2D assets and state clarity first. No new full-screen blur, depth-of-field or volumetric effects required. All sizes and timing below are starting specifications to validate on devices.

01 / Art direction and first impression

Current: a promising dungeon prototype wearing a developer HUD. Target: a field-worn adventurer instrument panel.



TARGET / supplied concept: tactile depth, strong portraits, concentrated controls



CURRENT / strong atmosphere, equal-weight panels and very small combat UI

Keep the mood, edit the composition
The concept succeeds through chunky silhouettes, inset portraits and warm/cool contrast. Its many beveled frames would crowd a phone if copied literally.

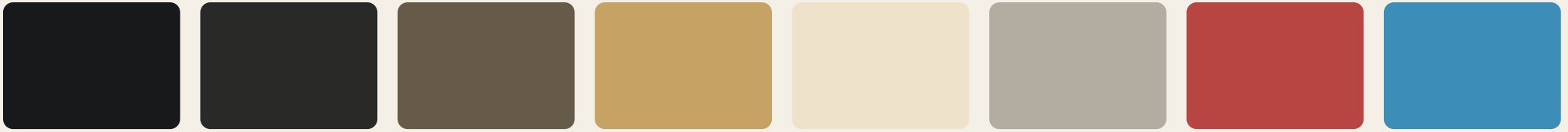
What currently works
The dungeon materials and torch pools establish place quickly. The portraits provide identity. A compact, consistent gold language already ties the HUD together.

My direction: blackened iron + aged brass
Use charcoal-grey panel faces with a brown undertone, matte brass edges and warm ivory text. Reserve bright gold for selected or actionable elements.

One engine, two skins
Share layout, input and state components with Void Crew. Swap token palette, frame atlas, icons, font roles and sounds. Keep fantasy filigree out of engine-level behavior.

02 / Frames, palette and typography

Make depth through value and a few assets, not a bevel around every nested rectangle.



Panel
#17191B

Raised
#292A28

Edge
#665B48

Brass
#C6A365

Text
#EEE3CA

Muted
#B2ADA0

HP
#B74541

Mana
#3C8EB8

Frame recipe
1 px dark outer silhouette, 1 px muted brass edge, 2 px inset shadow. Add 12-16 px corner caps only to major frames. Inner rows use spacing or a single divider. Panel opacity 94-98%; avoid expensive backdrop blur.

Button recipe
Dark face, light top edge, shaded bottom edge; icon sits inside a 2 px safe inset. Press moves content down 1 px. A selected tab gets a brass underline plus a marker, not just a color shift.

Type roles
Georgia Bold for major screen titles only (24-28 desktop / 22-24 mobile). Segoe UI or a bundled licensed humanist sans for names, controls and body. Monospaced digits only for timers. Embed fonts in the game build after licensing review.

Readability contract
Body 16 CSS px; names 14-16; secondary labels 12-14 desktop and 14 mobile. Warm ivory on near-black. Target 4.5:1 for small text and 3:1 for large text / essential UI outlines; measure final assets. Never place gold microtext directly on stone.

Small asset set: one 9-slice panel, three button states, four corner caps, one divider, one selected ring and a shared icon atlas. Use subtle baked grain; no animated noise. HUD labels stay English in this proposal; the Hungarian concept labels are mood reference only.

03 / Party, portraits and combat resources

The party should read in one glance: who is selected, who is hurt, who can act, and with what.



BEFORE / supplied screenshot



AFTER / schematic proposal, not final art

Portrait first; role second
Keep current character identities and artwork. Normalize face scale, eye line, background darkness and crop. Desktop card: portrait at left, name and resources at right; use expanded portraits in inventory. Avoid four full-size portrait cards on phones.

Resource clarity
Use a heart / droplet or HP / MP label and current / maximum values. Keep HP above MP everywhere. If the engine resource is energy, label EN; never rename it mana without changing the underlying rules.

Weapon = active action
Replace thin truncated weapon rows with an icon, short name and input hint. Tap selects / acts according to one consistent model; hold Aim has a visible hint. No-resource weapons show a relevant cost or no second bar, not a misleading empty mana bar.

Cooldown vocabulary
Dark radial or vertical veil, numeric countdown below 3 seconds, muted icon and disabled cursor. Ready gets one brief rim highlight. Queueable actions have a separate queued marker. HP loss animates immediately; a delayed pale trail reveals the amount lost.

04 / Minimap and log

Both are useful instruments. Neither should occupy a permanent wall of empty space.



BEFORE / repeated obstruction messages and an oversized empty log



BEFORE / map scale and camera framing change the navigation task

Map: simpler, less gold
Use muted parchment explored tiles on charcoal; unknown tiles remain blank. Player is a bright directional triangle with dark outline. Door = crossbar, objective = diamond, stairs = steps. Add a tiny legend on expansion; retain north-up and show facing.

Map behavior
Desktop 160-184 px; landscape 96-120; portrait 88-104. Tap opens a centered, larger map with 48 px zoom controls. Keep tile scale stable, pan to the player and mark vertical connections. Do not reveal unexplored routes accidentally.

Log: event strip, not console
Show the latest two meaningful events desktop and one mobile, then fade after 4-6 seconds outside combat. Keep a persistent history affordance and unread count. Use 16 px proportional text, generous line spacing and a solid text bed.

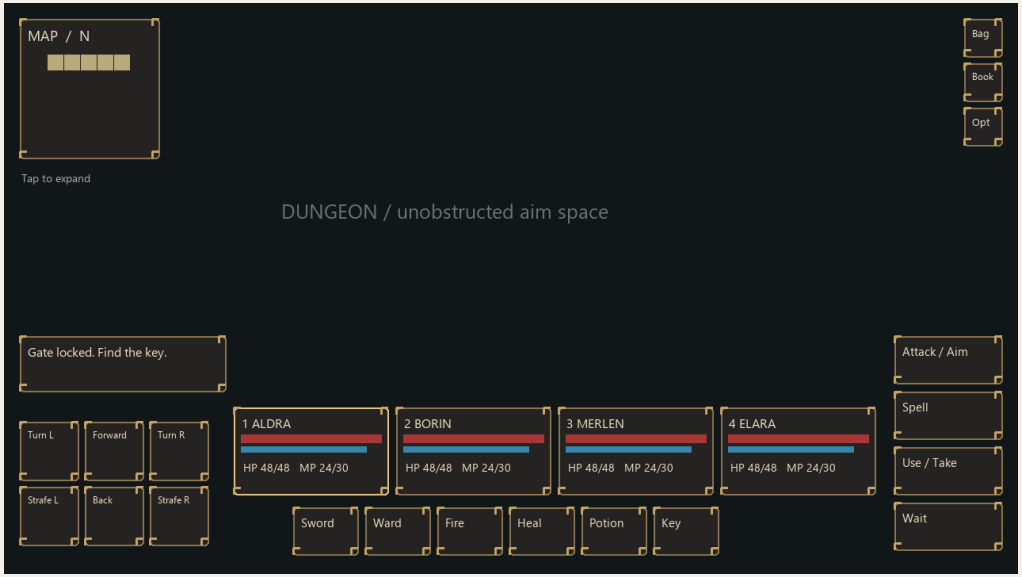
Deduplicate and prioritize
Replace five copies of "A bulkhead blocks the way" with "Blocked - iron gate" and a count in history. The sci-fi word bulkhead breaks the fantasy fiction. Critical damage / quest changes persist until acknowledged; chatter can expire. Do not overwrite a critical event with loot spam.

05 / Movement, actions and the desktop HUD

Schematic at 1280 x 720. Reallocate the debug region to the world; preserve a coherent bottom control shelf.



BEFORE / supplied screenshot



AFTER / schematic proposal, not final art

Movement needs six distinct meanings

Top row: turn left, forward, turn right. Bottom: strafe left, back, strafe right. Use curved arrows for turning and straight arrows for translation. Keyboard hints appear on hover or when keyboard input is detected.

Action hierarchy

Attack / Hold Aim is primary, then Spell, Use / Take, Wait. Context Use names its target when available. Keep Wait deliberately separated from Attack. Avoid an attack icon hidden among inventory navigation.

Hotbar and icon rail

Six visible desktop slots, configurable keys, icon and quantity / cooldown. Bag, journal and settings form a quiet upper-right rail. Tooltips supply labels. Do not copy every concept slot: empty ornamental slots consume valuable space.

Aim interaction

Press / hold enters bullet-time aim; release confirms only a valid target, cancel has a dedicated key / touch affordance. Make this model configurable if current gameplay uses tap-to-toggle. Show the actual slow-time state, not a fictitious stamina meter.

06 / Debug tools that stay out of the game

Keep the tools. Stop making them a permanent third of the product.



CURRENT / debug menu consumes a large fraction of a short screen



CURRENT / developer controls displace party and play controls

Desktop drawer, closed at launch
Open with F2 or a small Developer entry in settings. Width 320-360 px; overlay rather than resize the camera. Pinning is available for authoring. Label it DEVELOPER TOOLS; group scene, renderer, gameplay and performance separately.

Separate player settings
Sound, controls, graphics presets and accessibility belong in the player menu. World selection, material relief and smoke tuning belong in developer tools. Preserve both without exposing a production player to implementation terminology.

Interaction rules
Drawer has a clear close button, escape/back support, independent scrolling and remembered groups. Numeric sliders offer reset and direct value entry. Show changed values and a Reset section action; avoid accidental world reload on scroll.

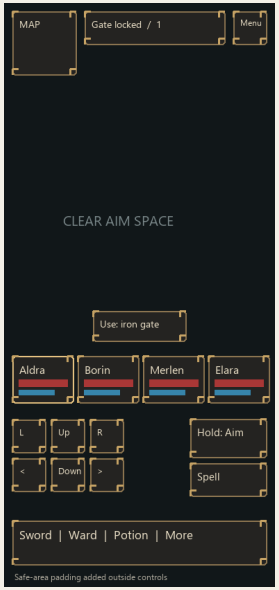
Mobile developer mode
Open as a nearly full-height sheet, with a fixed close/header and scrollable body. Do not imply the game paused if it still runs: show LIVE or pause explicitly in solo play. In shared real-time contexts, retain a small party danger indicator. Close restores previous focus and controls.

07 / Mobile layouts and touch

Design in CSS pixels, not screenshot pixels. Portrait and landscape require different compositions.



BEFORE / portrait



AFTER / portrait



BEFORE / landscape



AFTER / landscape

Portrait: recover the top and bottom

Shrink map to ~96 px and log to one line. Four compact selectors show name and resource strips; selected member opens details. Reserve bottom thumb zones for movement and aim, then a small quick-item shelf. The supplied portrait cards consume space while still truncating weapons.

Landscape: protect the center

Map and event strip stay in the upper corners. Movement low left, aim/use low right, compact party along bottom center. On short phones, move quick items behind a fan-out button and reduce party detail before shrinking touch targets.

Touch contract

48 x 48 CSS px recommended minimum, 8 px gaps; primary aim 64 px high. Movement supports press-repeat with a safe cadence and cancels on pointer exit. No hover-only meaning: tap-select then show details; long press is an optional shortcut.

Responsive and safe-area rules

Use env(safe-area-inset-*) plus 12 px edge padding. Test 390 x 844, 844 x 390 and 667 x 375. Reflow at available height as well as width. Keep status and focus when rotating. Camera FOV needs an aspect-aware policy; do not simply crop away threats. Offer left-handed thumb-zone swap.

08 / Scene presentation and combat overlays

The warm dungeon is a strong base. Stabilize visibility before adding post-processing.



DARK CORRIDOR / distant path becomes hard to read



WALL VIEW / strong material contrast and bright green foliage pull attention

Light, fog and grade
Keep warm torch pools and cool slate fill; reduce saturated violet shadows and neon green foliage. Raise dark-path readability through low-cost ambient fill and matched blue-grey fog, not a global exposure lift that blows out fire. Use stable exposure; avoid auto-exposure pumping as torches enter frame.

Mobile render budget
No gameplay DOF: grid routes, targets and pickups must stay sharp. Use analytic distance fog and baked material detail. One restrained bloom pass only if profiling supports it; otherwise emissive fire plus a few additive glow sprites. Cap particle count, screen coverage and resolution on low tier.

Vignette, aiming and targeting
Subtle static vignette in the 3D viewport only; do not darken HUD corners. In aim mode: small neutral reticle, target outline/brackets, range/occlusion state, cancel hint and "Time slowed" label. An obstructed target uses a broken bracket plus "Blocked", not color alone.

Damage, healing and floating text
Local portrait flash + world-edge damage cue; no repeated full-screen red wash. Heal with a brief teal/ivory pulse and +value near the member. World numbers are optional, pooled and capped; merge repeated hits, fade within ~700 ms, never cover reticle. Reduced effects disables flashes and camera shake.

09 / Missing states and secondary screens

Build the state vocabulary before producing many custom screens.



PROPOSED / reusable state components and secondary-screen structures

Party and aiming

Selected = brass marker + name emphasis. Damaged = brief rim + delayed loss trail. Critical = persistent low-HP symbol, no endless pulse. Downed = desaturated portrait, crossed resource strip, explicit Revive action. Aim highlights the acting member and valid target; invalid action states say why.

Tooltips and inventory

Desktop tooltip after 350 ms: name, cost, effect, cooldown and input. Phone uses an anchored detail sheet with explicit action. Inventory: party selector, gear slots, 6 x 4 desktop grid and item details; phone uses tabs and a smaller scrolling grid. Equip / Give / Drop are explicit and support undo where possible.

Dialogue and toasts

Dialogue panel anchors above the control shelf, with speaker portrait/name, readable 55-70 character lines and large numbered choices. Pause or live behavior is explicit. Toasts stack at most two, avoid map/reticle, and route overflow to history. Loot toast includes quantity; errors name the remedy.

Loading and failure

Use one existing dungeon crop, logo, true loading stages and one control tip. Determinate progress only when measurable. Add a Retry action for failure and allow settings access. On return, restore orientation, selected member and hotbar. Avoid invented lore text that masks an indefinite stall.

10 / Animation and feedback

Every movement should explain state. Keep the heavy machinery still.

Button press / 60-90 ms
Face depresses 1 px; soft click. Pointer-down feedback is immediate.

Drawer / sheet / 140-180 ms
Translate 12-20 px and fade; no long screen-spanning travel.

HP loss / Immediate + 350 ms trail
Red fill updates immediately; pale loss segment catches up after 150 ms.

Healing / resource gain / 200-300 ms
Fill grows to true value, short local highlight; number is authoritative.

Cooldown ready / 120 ms, once
Single rim glint and optional quiet sound; no perpetual particle effect.

Selection / targeting / 80-120 ms
Marker appears, portrait rim brightens; reticle stays stable.

Loot / toast / 120 in, 160 out
Hold 3-5 s; history retains the message.

Reduced motion / 0-80 ms
Replace slides, pulses, shake and screen flashes with static state changes.

Implementation: animate transform and opacity on a small HUD layer. Avoid animating layout, large shadows or backdrop filters. Reuse pooled combat labels; keep React out of per-frame scene updates. Couple sounds to semantic events and cap duplicate hits. Profile UI compositing alongside the three.js render, especially additive overdraw.

11 / Component specification

Starting dimensions in logical CSS px. Desktop reference 1280 x 720; mobile 390 x 844 / 844 x 390. Do not scale the entire HUD as a bitmap.

COMPONENT	DESKTOP	MOBILE
Panel / spacing	12-16 padding; 8 / 16 gaps	12 padding; 8 gaps
Frame corners	12-16 caps; 1 px outline	10-12 caps; 1 px outline
Party card	190-210 x 100-120	86-92 x 64-72 compact
Portrait	72-88 square in HUD	32-40 in expanded selector; 72+ in detail
HP / MP strip	12 / 8 high + 14 px values	8 / 6 high; values in selected detail
Weapon / action	48-56 high; label 14-16	48-56 high; icon + short label
Movement key	56-64 square; 8 gap	48-56 square; 8 gap
Primary aim	128-160 x 56-64	96-112 x 56-64
Hotbar / rail slot	48-56 square; 8 gap	48 square; 4 slots + More if needed
Minimap	160-184 square	88-104 portrait; 96-120 landscape
Log / history	280-320 wide, 2 lines	180-220 wide, 1 line; full sheet history
Drawer / dialogue	320-360 wide / 600-720 wide	Screen width minus 24 + safe insets
Tooltip / menu row	240-300 wide / 40-48 high	Detail sheet / 48-56 high
Title / body / label	24-28 / 16 / 12-14	22-24 / 16 / 14

At minimum landscape height, collapse detail before reducing control sizes. These are layout targets, not measured dimensions of the supplied screenshots. Validate with real finger input, 200% text settings where supported, and device safe areas.

12 / Delivery plan and acceptance checks

Sequence the work so each phase improves the game independently. Estimates assume existing UI components and reusable portrait art.

In a day / highest return
Close debug by default; expose F2 and a Developer menu entry. Remove oversized empty log; deduplicate messages and fix "bulkhead" wording. Increase names/action text and add selected member + numeric resources. Define palette/type/spacing tokens. Keep art changes minimal.

In a week / coherent playable HUD
Build one frame/button kit and icon atlas. Reflow desktop and both phone orientations; implement explicit movement/aim touch controls, safe areas, cooldown, downed and tooltip states. Wire event feedback and separate player settings. Validate on a modest phone before polishing ornament.

Later / expand only after playtests
Inventory and dialogue component systems, remapping, left-handed mode, accessibility preferences and persistence. Commission matching icon/portrait touch-ups if needed. Add sparse corner ornaments and sound polish. Reuse the semantic components in Void Crew with a separate skin.

Keep scope honest
Do not budget new cinematic renders, full-screen DOF or ornate unique panels for every menu. A single reusable brass/iron kit should carry the mood. Keep high/low scene presets; measure each post-process addition on device. Timings and GPU cost cannot be established from screenshots.

Acceptance checks

1. A new player can identify selected character, HP, ready weapon, Use and Aim within five seconds.
2. On 667 x 375 and 390 x 844, no essential target is below 48 CSS px or covered by a safe-area inset.
3. Aim, occlusion, cooldown, damage, downed and revive states remain distinguishable in greyscale.
4. Closing menus restores focus and controls; rotation does not reset selected character or aim unexpectedly.
5. Compare the same corridor before/after on a target phone: HUD adds no sustained frame-time regression outside the agreed budget; prioritize a stable chosen 30 or 60 fps target over more effects.
6. In dark scenes, route and enemy silhouettes remain readable while HP, map and reticle stay crisp.

Review basis: the eight supplied images only; no playable build, performance capture or interaction audit. The proposed layouts are explanatory wireframes, not finished asset paintovers. Small geometry issues and low-resolution desktop pixel detail were excluded from judgment.